

BY SHIV VISVANATHAN

Jean Luc Godard, the French filmmaker, had a perceptive comment on Hollywood. He observed that America was a nation of migrants without a perception of America. They were exiles, ethnics, refugees with memories of a different world. Each had his own ambitions of survival and success but there was no collective institution to create a common dream of America. Enter Hollywood. It was Hollywood that sustained the American dream. A collective conscious Hollywood linked disparate ethnics into the search for a common fantasy. Hindi film plays a similar role but within a different grammar of expectations. India as a popular culture was framed by four codes—cricket, science, politics and film.

Politics, especially the vision of India as the world's largest hearted democracy gave one a special identity. It was our USP. People celebrated

democracy for itself. It was a value they wished to guarantee even if it did not often lead to good governance. If politics creates democracy, science guarantees security and development. In a formal sense, science is a passport to modernity, a guarantee that every citizen has a right to knowledge in a knowledge-dominated world. If science and democracy are guarantees of empowerment, cricket and film are rules in the game of modernity. Cricket was a discourse before it became a game. We were great spectators, commentators, before we became great players. Cricket was our form of cosmopolitanism as play, while cinema was all myth. Cinema related to culture at four levels. It reflected civilisation; it conversed with nation and nation state; it echoed civil society; and it resonated folk and mass culture. It was a hierarchy of resonances creating unity through emergence.

This celebration of unity must begin with an ode to the greatest sociologist of cinema. History has been unfair to him by hailing him solely as the storyteller of the Partition. That he was, but Sadat Hassan Manto was also a delightful gossip and raconteur, salacious, tolerant and utterly wicked. He created the myth of Bombay Talkies as an alternative to the fact of the Partition. If Partition officially divided Hindu and Muslim into the dreariness of nation-states, the Bombay talkies showed that Hindi films as a creative unity needed the complementarity of Hindu and Muslim. The scandal, the gossip, the style of Bombay Talkies needed their jugalbandi to survive. Manto's stories were a microcosm of the India he loved and left and could not abandon.

While the cultural unity of India began with films as an answer to the Partition, Bombay Talkies was realistic enough to add to the nostalgia of unity, a new mythical rendition of the Nehruvian nation-state. If any rhetoric ever captured the unity of the Preamble, the we-ness of the democratic, socialist, modern nation, it was Hindi film. Our film was not a modernist appeal to liberty, equality and fraternity but to its more collective variant of unity, diversity and integrity not within a closed universe, but with a cosmopolitan vision of the world.

The trinity of Raj Kapoor, Dilip Kumar and Dev Anand represented a unity that no other *trishul* could match. As an anthem, Kapoor's *Mera joota hai Japani* was as powerful and resonant as *Vande Mataram* or *Jana Gana Mana*. Hindi film showed that the Indian experiment in modernity needed no identity crisis. Being Indian was a noun. It needed no verbs of migration, conversion, no rituals of mobility. One just was in that availability of selves we called Indian culture.

Indian films never claim the homogeneity of one unity. They are a collection of unities. There is the unity of the flag, the musical unity that Lata Mangeshkar and Kishore Kumar provided, the theatrical unity of Balraj Sahni, the Chaplinesque-socialist unity of Kapoor, the soil-soaked unity of *Mother India*, the official unity of Nehru and Gandhi; the unity of hero and heroine, one anchored in the north and the other emerging from the south. It was a Vyjayanthimala to every Dilip Kumar, which later became a Hema Malini to every Dharmendra or even later a Sridevi to every Anil Kapoor, and Jai Hind to that. It was this dialect of unities that made the official superficial. Hindi film was a

